Jet Fuel Costs a Record High, So Holiday Flights Cost More

From: NPR World Mined: 2026-10-23 3 min read

Do you hope to fly somewhere for the holidays? Your ticket will probably cost more this year.

The reason is **jet fuel**, the special fuel that planes burn. Fuel is one of the biggest costs for airlines, and its price just hit a record. On Thursday, **jet fuel** in the United States cost an average of $4.90 a **gallon**, said the tracking firm Argus. That is the highest price the firm has ever recorded, and more than twice last year's price.

Airlines are passing some of this cost to passengers. Hayley Berg, an **economist** at the travel company Hopper, said **airfares** are at a 10-year high. Thanksgiving tickets cost about 30% more than last year, and Christmas tickets are up more than 20%.

Still, most people are buying tickets. One Maryland traveler said family tickets cost too much, so she will drive to Chicago instead. Many others booked early to lock in a **fare** before prices climb higher.

Word Treasure

jet fuel -- Jet fuel is the special fuel that airplanes burn to fly.
airfares -- Airfares are the prices people pay for plane tickets.
economist -- An economist is a person who studies money, prices, and how people spend.
gallon -- A gallon is a unit used to measure liquids like fuel.
fare -- A fare is the price you pay to travel, such as for a plane ticket.

Background you need

Jet fuel is the special fuel that airplanes burn to fly, and airlines must buy huge amounts of it.

When the price of fuel goes up, flying costs airlines much more money.

To cover the extra cost, airlines often raise ticket prices, especially at busy holiday times when many families want to travel.

Break it down

WHO: Airlines, an economist at Hopper, and holiday travelers in the United States
WHAT: Jet fuel hit a record price, so airlines are passing some of the cost to passengers in higher ticket prices
WHERE: In the United States, for holiday trips such as Thanksgiving and Christmas flights
WHY: Fuel is one of the biggest costs for airlines, so when its price rises, tickets cost more too

Why it matters

If your family flies to visit relatives for the holidays, higher ticket prices could change where you go or how you get there.

Test what you remember

1. Why will holiday flights probably cost more this year?

- (A) Because airports are closed
- (B) Because jet fuel costs more than ever
- (C) Because planes are bigger this year
- (D) Because fewer people want to fly

2. How much did jet fuel cost on Thursday in the United States, on average?

- (A) Twice a ticket price
- (B) A 10-year high
- (C) $4.90 a gallon
- (D) About 30% more

3. Who said airfares are at a 10-year high?

- (A) Hayley Berg
- (B) A Maryland traveler
- (C) The airlines
- (D) Argus

4. How much more do Thanksgiving tickets cost than last year?

- (A) About 30% more
- (B) About the same
- (C) More than 20% more
- (D) Half as much

5. What did one Maryland traveler decide to do because family tickets cost too much?

- (A) Stay home
- (B) Fly at Christmas instead
- (C) Book very early
- (D) Drive to Chicago instead

6. Why did many other people book their tickets early?

- (A) Because fuel is cheaper on Thursdays
- (B) To get a window seat
- (C) To lock in a fare before prices climb higher
- (D) To travel with family

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: A 4: A 5: D 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Hayley Berg, an economist at the travel company Hopper: She said airfares are at a 10-year high, with Thanksgiving tickets costing about 30% more than last year and Christmas tickets up more than 20%.

2. One Maryland traveler: She said family tickets cost too much, so she will drive to Chicago instead of flying.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):